

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us
reason to reject premise (2) of the foreknowledge
argument?

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That
is good for the defender of free will.

We'll shortly consider some ways of responding to Edwards' argument. But first let's think about how Edwards' argument might be related to an argument for fatalism.

Suppose that someone did not believe in God — and hence rejected premise (2) of Edwards' argument — but did believe that there were truths about all of our future actions. Could they give an argument similar to Edwards' argument?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of another universe, which had its own system of time and space. And suppose one was given all of the information about everything that ever happens in that universe, and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you know everything about every free action in that universe. But it's not like you knew of every action **before** that action occurred — you don't exist in the time of that universe.

Let's look again at the premises which make
reference to time.

1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)

We started off with two arguments for the reality of fate.

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was based on the Law of the Excluded Middle.

The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

Now consider the second argument for fate which we discussed earlier: the theological argument. This is not an argument likely to trouble an atheist. But can the theist reasonably deny that God knows our future?

But what if we denied this? Perhaps claims about future free actions — like claims about what you will eat for dinner tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply “undetermined.” They do not now have any truth-value (though they will later).

This view — that God exists, but does not know our future actions — is called open theism.

There are two central objections to open theism.

The first is just that it amounts to a denial of God's
omniscience.

But here the open theist who thinks that claims about future actions have no truth-value has a not-unreasonable reply. She can say that she is not denying God's omniscience, because she is not denying that God knows all of the truths. She is just denying that there are any truths about future actions to be known (yet).

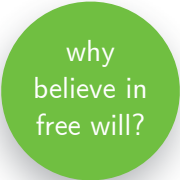
(A tricky question is whether you can still be this kind of open theist if you think that God exists outside of time.)



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

reason to reject premise (2) of the forkwledge

Does the claim that God exists outside of time give us

argument?

is good for the defendant free will.

It does look like, if Aquinas' view is right, (2) is false. That

We'll shortly consider some ways of

responding to Edwards' argument. But

for fatalsn.

first let's think about how Edwards'

argument might be related to an argument

Suppose that someone did not believe in

Edwards' argument — but did believe that

similar to Edwards' argument?

there were truths about all our future

actions. Could they give an argument

God— and hence rejected premise (2) of





and the time at which it happens. So, in particular, you

before that action occurred — you don't exist in the

space. And suppose now was given all of the information

about everything that ever happens in that universe,

another universe, which had its own system of time and

time of that universe.

know everything about every fre action in that

To get a grip on this, imagine that one learned of

universe. But it's not like you know every action

reference to time.

Let's look again at the premises which make



overtire actioids.

3. We have not checked that

God knows that in the end I will

2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of

1. We have no choice about past facts.

performance: (1, 2)

The first was the Logical Argument for Fate, which was



based on the Labeled Middle



For any proposition P , either P is

The Law of the excluded middle

the Not-IP the.

Now consider the second argument for fat we discussed

earlier: the theological argument. This is not an argument likely

God knows our future?

to trouble an atheist. But can the theist reasonably deny that

But what if we denied this? Perhaps about future free

(though they will later).

'undetermined.' They do not now have any truth-value

actions—like claim about what you will eat for dinner

tonight — are neither true nor false, but simply

actions — is called open theism.

This view — that God exists, but does not know our future



The first is just that it amounts to a denial of God's

denying that God knows all of the truths. She is just denying that

saying that she is not denying God's omniscience, because she is not

actions have no truth-value has a not-unable reply. She can

But here the pentheist who thinks that claims about future

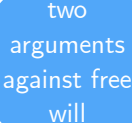
there are any truths about future actions to be known (yet).

(A tricky question is whether you can still be this kind of open

theist if you think that God exists outside of time.)

freedom that comes from fate.

Our first topic today is the oldest challenge to the existence of free will: the challenge to



two
arguments
against free
will



is fate
real?



why
believe in
free will?



three
ways out

(5) Let's look at what happens if we

God only shows up in premises (2) and

with reference to the being of truth about

our future actions.

replace reference to God's foreknowledge



4. If we have no choice about p , and no

5* We have not noticed the fact



perform a certain action (1,2)

some action, then I will prefer that

2*In the past, there were truths about

1. We have no direct facts.

then we have the choice about q.

3 We have not at the fact that

God knows that in the future I will

that if it is true that I will perform

0 We have achieved what we

all of our activities.

choice about the fact that if p , then q ,

(3, 4, 5)

will perform various actions.

acaioid.

The fatalist argument

So now consider a possible scenario in which someone exactly like you would get

that Predict did not **take away** their free will; it just shows them that they

never had any. So they lacked free will before getting a Predicto.

a Predictor. By the above line of thought, this person would lack free will. But

either.

But this person was stipulated to be exactly like you. So you don't have free will,

and the example of the Predictor — which seem to show that if there is such a

things as fate, then there is no free will.

So far we've looked at two imaginary thought experiments—the story of Osmo,

Our question is: do either fatigue or foreknowledge pose a

serious challenge to the reality of free will?

There are truths
about our future
actions.

In the past, God
had
foreknowledge of
our future
actions.



1. We have no choice about past facts.
2. In the past, God had foreknowledge of our future actions.
3. We have no choice about the fact that God knows that in the future I will perform a certain action. (1,2)



The law of the excluded middle

For any proposition P , either P is true or $\text{Not-}P$ is true.

There are two central objections to open theism.